

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD X7-0 (A)
Rec'd 1/29/01 vpl**Species:** Lesser Black-backed Gull (*Larus fuscus*)**Date:** 8 October 2000 **Number seen:** one **Sex:** unknown **Plumage:** Adult basic**Locality:** Pueblo Reservoir, south marina**Elevation:****Nearest town:** Pueblo**County:** Pueblo**Time observed:** late morning**Duration of observation:** ~10 minutes**Description:**

While scanning through the gull flock sitting on the tires at the south marina, I noticed a large-sized gull with a darker back than the other gulls it was standing with - California (*L. californicus*), Ring-billed (*L. delawarensis*), and Franklin's (*L. pipixcan*). This gull was in basic adult plumage with solidly dark slaty-gray wings and mantle, light head with heavy, dark brown streaking that extended down the neck, a bright yellow, long, fairly thick [not chunky however like Western (*L. occidentalis*)] bill with a substantial black ring, reminiscent of *L. delawarensis*. There was a small red spot on the lower mandible in front of the black on the bill. Its eyes and legs were both bright yellow. The underparts were white. It also had large white scapular and tertial crescents. Wingtips were black with white mirrors, but I did not notice the primary extension. This gull was only slightly larger than *L. californicus* standing nearby.

I used Nat. Geo. 3rd ed. to show Elena the gulls we were seeing and their differences. We went through the field marks for *L. fuscus* one-by-one - yellow eyes and legs, similar size as *L. californicus* with a darker back, and heavily streaked head and neck to confirm its identity.

Separation from similar species:

The combination of yellow legs and eyes rules out all North American gulls, except Ring-billed (*L. delawarensis*) and Yellow-footed (*L. livens*). *Larus delawarensis* is easily eliminated by much larger size, drastically darker back, and red gonydeal dot. *Larus livens* is slightly trickier, but is also fairly easily dismissed. *Larus livens* is a humongous gull, larger than *L. occidentalis*, with a massively heavy bill, both of which this bird did not exhibit.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): I heard none.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen dozens of LBBGs, including several from the winter of 1999-2000 in Colorado.

Light conditions: 100% overcast, cold, windy

Optical equipment used: Kowa 20-60x

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest distance at 200 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Elena Thomas

Other observers who saw the bird independently: this (or possibly another) LBBG was reported several days afterwards by Brandon Percival and others.

If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: National Geographic Birds of North America, 3rd ed. I showed Elena the different types of gulls there and helped her locate the features needed to identify them.

Reporting observer: Doug Faulkner

Signature:

Doug Faulkner

Address: Rocky Mountain Bird Observatory, 14500 Lark Bunting Lane, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: This report was put together on 10 January 2001 directly from notes written on 11 Oct 2000.